

Nielsen Norman Group

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

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Task:

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

- No loading or progress indicators when submitting forms or navigating pages.
- No success/confirmation messages after completing actions like save or submit.
- No clear visual highlight to show which page, tab, or button is currently active.
 - Users are left unsure whether the system is processing or if an action succeeded.

Recommendations

- Add simple loading spinners or progress bars during form submission or page transitions.
- Display clear, short success/error banners or pop-ups immediately after every action.
- Highlight active navigation items using consistent color, underline, or bold styling.
- Ensure feedback appears within 1–2 seconds and stays visible long enough to be read.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

- Icons are used without descriptive text labels, making their meaning difficult to understand.
- Content and controls are arranged in an order that does not follow natural top-to-bottom, left-to-right reading or task flow.

Recommendations

- Replace jargon and unclear labels with simple, everyday terms
- Add short text labels directly below or beside all icons to explain their purpose.
- Rearrange content and form fields to follow logical reading order and common task sequences.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is Undo and Redo supported?

Issues

- No visible "Back", "Cancel", or "Undo" buttons inside forms or multi-step processes.
- No easy way to return to a previous screen or leave a task without starting over.
- No confirmation prompts before performing permanent or high-risk actions such as delete or submit.

Recommendations

- Place clearly labeled Back, Cancel, and Undo buttons at the top or bottom of every form/process.
- Include a persistent Home button on every screen so users can restart anytime.
- Add a confirmation dialog: "Are you sure you want to delete this? This cannot be undone."

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

- Buttons differ in size, shape, color, and hover style from one page to another.
- Navigation menu changes position, order, or wording across different screens.
- The same action (e.g. save, search) uses different icons or labels in different places.
- Font sizes, text styles, and spacing are inconsistent throughout the design.

Recommendations

- Adopt a consistent design system: use the same set of colors, fonts, and button styles everywhere.
- Keep the main navigation bar in the same location, with identical labels, on every screen.
- Standardize icons and wording so the same action always looks and works the same way.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

- No input restrictions, format hints, or real-time validation — users can enter invalid data.
- No warning appears when the user tries to leave a half-completed form.
- No confirmation before performing actions that permanently remove or overwrite data.

Recommendations

- Add clear format examples inside fields and validate inputs as the user types.
- Block invalid characters or formats and highlight errors early.
- Show a warning prompt: “You have unsaved changes — leave this page anyway?”
- Always require confirmation for delete, clear, or final submit actions.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user’s memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

- No breadcrumb navigation to show users where they are in the system.
- Related fields and options are not visually grouped, making it hard to scan and remember.
- Important instructions or labels disappear when scrolling or moving between screens.

Recommendations

- Add breadcrumb trails at the top so users always know their current location.
- Group related elements together using spacing, headings, or borders.
- Keep essential labels, help text, and navigation visible at all times.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

- No shortcuts, quick actions, or faster ways to complete common tasks.
- All users must follow the same full steps, even for actions performed often.
- Layout elements do not resize or rearrange well on mobile phones or smaller screens.

Recommendations

- Add quick-action buttons, keyboard shortcuts, or gestures for frequent tasks.
- Allow users to save form drafts, favorite pages, or default settings for faster future use.
- Make the layout fully responsive so it works well on both desktop and mobile.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

- Pages feel cluttered with too many elements, small text, and cramped spacing.
- Unnecessary decorations, colors, or repeated information distract from the main purpose.
- Low contrast between text and background makes reading difficult; buttons are too small.

Recommendations

- Remove all unnecessary elements; keep only what is essential for completing tasks.
- Establish a clear visual hierarchy: emphasize headings, separate body text, and make buttons stand out.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

- Errors are missing, vague, or shown only as codes with no explanation.
- No clear indication of which specific field or action caused the error.
- No helpful instructions on how to correct the mistake.

Recommendations

- Replace codes with plain, simple language: "Please enter a valid email address."
- Highlight the problematic field in red and place the explanation right next to it

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

- No built-in help, tips, or instructions to guide users.
- If help exists, it is hidden deep in menus or difficult to find.
- No FAQs, step-by-step guides, or context-specific guidance provided.

Recommendations

- Add small (?) help icons beside complex fields, opening short tips on click.
- Include a permanent, easy-to-find Help / Guide link in the main navigation.
- Write help content in simple steps, directly related to the current page or task.